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ALEX MENDELSON

Ecologist, Field Biologist

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Field biologist with experience in California vegetation and wildlife surveys, coastal restoration, and construction-adjacent monitoring. Skilled in transect-based surveys, habitat assessment, and environmental data collection under variable field conditions. Strong background in data analysis (R, Python) and technical writing, with the ability to work independently, travel, and collaborate with multidisciplinary field teams. Seeking to transition into environmental consulting and compliance-focused fieldwork.

Education

MS Biology | California State University, Northridge — Expected May 2026

BS Biology (Zoology, Botany, and Ecology) | California State University, Long Beach — 2022

Field Experience

Restoration Intern | Tidal Influence, LLC, Long Beach, CA — 2023

- Conducted vegetation and avian surveys using line transects and quadrats in coastal restoration sites
- Supported environmental compliance monitoring during construction activities
- Assisted in native plant propagation and greenhouse management for restoration projects
- Monitored restoration site water quality
- Maintained and supported trail infrastructure and site access

Restoration Intern | Bolsa Chica Conservancy, Huntington Beach, CA — 2021–2023

- Performed long-term vegetation monitoring and habitat assessments in sensitive coastal wetlands
- Conducted vegetation mapping and patch analysis to support restoration and mitigation planning
- Assisted in endangered plant mitigation efforts, including monitoring and documentation
- Collected field data under variable environmental conditions and maintained accurate field records

Technical Skills

Field & Survey

- Vegetation monitoring (line/area transects, mapping)
- California native plant ID
- Avian surveys (visual & auditory ID)
- Water quality assessment (pH, salinity, DO_2, turbidity)

Compliance Support

- Field data collection and documentation
- Construction-adjacent monitoring
- Habitat assessment and restoration support

Data & Software

- R (statistical analysis)
- Python (automation, data processing)
- ImageJ, Fiji, Ilastik, OpenCV (image analysis)
- Adobe Creative Suite
- MS Excel and Word
- Google Sheets

Professional Service

Tree Canopy Assessment Research Project | US Forest Service, CSUN Urban Forestry 2026
Fire-affected neighborhoods of Altadena, CA

President | Behavior, Ecology, and Evolution Research Club 2024–2025
California State University, Northridge

Research Experience

Graduate Research 2023–present
terHorst Evolutionary Ecology Lab, California State University, Northridge

- Designed and conducted ecological experiments on temperature effects in aquatic microfauna
- Managed large datasets and automated analysis workflows
- Advanced image analysis for biological measurements
- Produced and presented results at regional and national conferences

Research Assistant 2021–2023
Pernet Larval Biology Lab, California State University, Long Beach

- Established the settlement strategy of an economically important marine fouling species
- Developed novel larval rearing and feeding systems
- Field collections of various marine invertebrates

Presentations

** denotes presenter*

Mendelson, A. A*., C. P. terHorst. 2025. The search for indirect ecological effect of evolution in pitcher plant rotifers. Western Society of Naturalists, San Diego, CA [**talk**]

Mendelson, A. A*., C. P. terHorst. 2025. Does response to increased temperature differ among clones of pitcher plant rotifers? Evolution, Athens, GA [**poster**]

Mendelson, A. A*., C. P. terHorst. P. 2024. Different effects of temperature on pitcher plant rotifer clones. Ecological Society of America, Long Beach, CA [**poster**]

Mendelson, A. A*., C. P. terHorst. 2024. Ecological effect of evolution in pitcher plant rotifers as a response to temperature stress. CSUNposium, Northridge, CA [**poster**]

Mendelson, A. A*., K. Nuon, B. Pernet. 2022, 2023. It's all a big mistake: larval errors and the formation of new aggregations of the serpulid annelid *Ficopomatus enigmaticus*. Western Society of Naturalists, Monterey, CA [**talk**]; Southern California Academy of Sciences, Santa Barbara, CA [**talk**]; California Estuarine Research Society, Costa Mesa, CA [**poster**]; Western Society of Naturalists, Oxnard, CA [**poster**]

Publications

Mendelson, A. A., K. Nuon, B. Pernet. (2025). Gregarious and non-gregarious larval settlement in the aggregation-forming annelid *Ficopomatus enigmaticus*. *Biol. Bull.* Online ahead of print.